

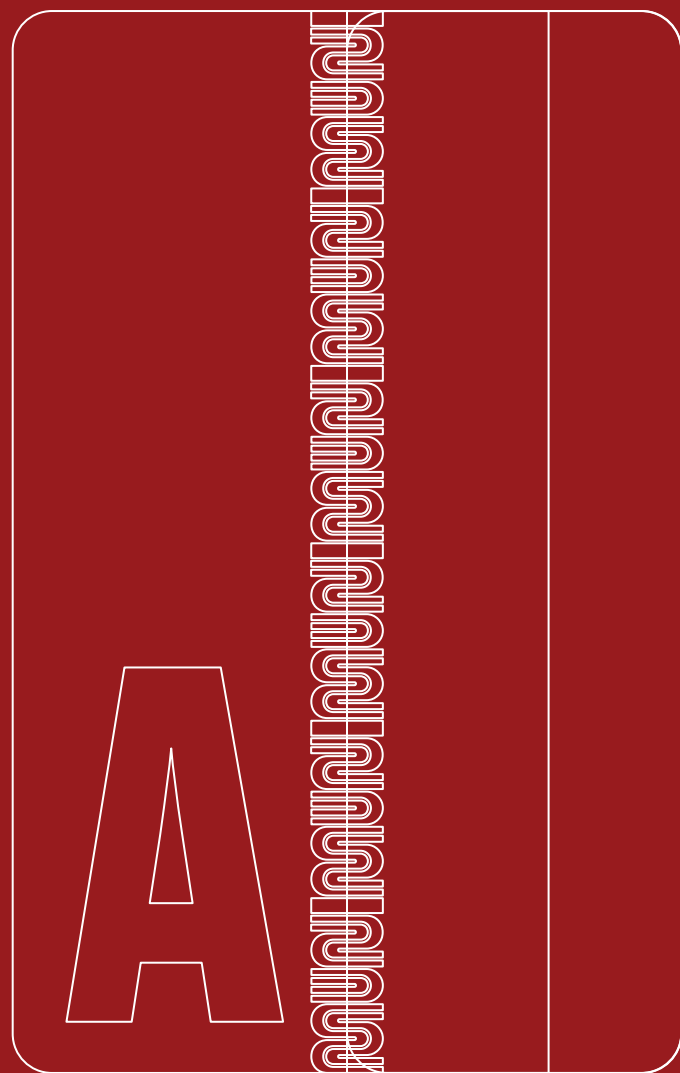


COMMUNITY

KEEP SF MOVING



VOLUME 1 ISSUE 3



KEEP SF MOVING  **VOLUME 1 ■ ISSUE 3**



WELCOME TO COMMUNITY

A COMMUNITY MAGAZINE CELEBRATING
THE PEOPLE'S RAILWAY

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JOSE ALVAREZ - WEST PORTAL STATION

A LETTER FROM THE EDITOR

As you walk around San Francisco, you can't miss the signs of people yearning, begging, for community. Take note on your next stroll around the block and I promise you won't be able to ignore it. Some are literal signs — flyers wrapped around every pole that advertise book clubs and neighborhood clean ups. But you'll witness the edges of parks overtaken by run clubs; strangers lighting each other's cigarettes outside of dive bars.

In case you missed this gem from the last issue of the magazine, we touched on the concept of San Francisco's Living Room, the idea that it's found on every train and bus seat and cable car — a shared, democratized space that generously and altruistically offers us a much greater service than getting us from point A to point B. This is the central premise of *COMMUNITY*: Muni is one of the most powerful and most important ways that we create and nourish communities.

Some of my favorite moments over the last few months have been running into familiar characters while I walk to and/or ride Muni. Along Waller, I wave to Father Dan (to whom I'd never admit that I haven't stepped into a church in the last decade) as he instinctively searches his pocket to secure a treat for my dog. I turn down Cole and run into the clerk from Gus's Market who has evolved from someone who rings up my vegetables to a warm reassurance that I am home. I continue down, picking up the pace ever so slightly so I don't miss my next chance at the N, and catch the eye of a friend of a friend who lives in Cole Valley. We exchange a quick promise to meet up for drinks at Woods soon. As I climb the short steps and tap my Clipper, my friend Karen's face emerges amidst a sea of backpacks – instant smiles and a hug before we both head off to work.

Unquantifiable, perhaps, but I can confidently say my daily Muni journeys have fortified each one of these relationships in a profound way. Every nicety, wave, hug, and interaction reminds me that I'm not alone, that we all have more in common than we think, even if it's just a shared bus route. Simply put, every ride inevitably pushes me deeper into my community because it reminds me that none of us are meant to experience this world alone.

Plus, the more I talk about my experiences on Muni; my love for (and my frustrations) with this system; and for the power of transit in general, the more people come to me with questions and commentary and musings stemming from their own experiences with Muni (running this magazine undoubtedly helps facilitate those conversations, too). In the same way that every Chicagoan can commiserate with each other about a cold winter day and revel at the first glimpse of sun in the spring, every San Franciscan can be equally united by their shared experiences cramming into a busy 22 bus and admiring the views of Dolores Park from the J.

And we need that more than ever.



PHOTO CREDIT:
ALEX BENAUMIN



We are all starting to hear about the upcoming local and regional ballot measures. 'Tis the season of coming home to handfuls of flyers and posters stuffed in mailboxes with in-your-face capital letters and prospective candidates' faces plastered all over the paper in bold colors, with messaging printed on it with such conviction it seems impossible to ever know what to trust. Before we know it, we'll be standing in line at the polls or huddling around kitchen tables bubbling in our ballots, and we will be faced with two seemingly simple questions that will actually determine the fate of all public transit systems in the Bay.

Whatever your feeling is about Muni or public transit at large, I can tell you our city will look much worse if those measures fail. Reduced service and closure of critical routes and lines — among other things — will equate to more cars on the road, longer commutes to work, less investment in accessibility, more challenges to see friends and more barriers to shop at local businesses and hop between parks and every beautiful thing that happens in the middle. And then what will we have? What will we lose as a community? I'm not willing to find out.

While we all continue to crave community, we are lucky that we don't need to dig that much to find it here. We just need to slow down. To participate in the systems that already exist and to make them stronger. It takes work. But we can't yearn for community, we can't force it, without first being willing to invest in it. And while I myself will continue to light the cigarettes of strangers outside of dive bars (though I'll admit, no promises on joining in on those run clubs), I believe the first step is recognizing and supporting what we have right in front of our noses that will cater to that deep-seated need. That need we all have. To connect with one another.

So sit back, kick your feet up (but not literally, please) and enjoy what San Francisco's Living Room has to offer. You won't be sorry.

Keep reading and keep riding,

JAC MATTER RESNIK

Founder, editor-in-chief

"BUT WE CAN'T
YEARN FOR
COMMUNITY, WE
CAN'T FORCE IT,
WITHOUT FIRST
BEING WILLING
TO INVEST IN IT."



PHOTO CREDIT:
JOSE ALVAREZ

A NOTE ON THE DESIGN

Dear reader, welcome to *COMMUNITY*, a labor of love to the city we call home. In these pages you will find writing, art, and photography celebrating the wheels, rails, and streets of San Francisco. All uncredited photos are taken by yours truly. Thank you, Dylan Fabris, for rescuing my SD card after I left it behind, 1,000 miles from home, so you could see the picture at right. Beyond that, I'd like to say a few special thank yous to some of the font designers turned digital preservationists who have allowed us to bring their work to these pages.

First and foremost is **EMILY SNEDDON**, whose font **FRAN SANS** she freely provided to us. Sneddon, out of Melbourne, reverse-engineered **MUNI'S BREDA LAV'S SIGNAGE** logic into a proper digital typeface: a mechanical, segmented glyph set never meant to be a font at all. Her work here has allowed us to bring one of Muni's most iconic letterforms into a new life as bullets, headers, and many other ends far less auspicious than a Breda's destination marquee.

A second thank you goes to **BEN ZOTTO**, for the font **FOG CITY GOTHIC**, which you will recognize from the header, and the titling of all following pieces. Zotto, a type-obsessed engineer like me, inadvertently became a preservationist while researching the history of **SAN FRANCISCO'S STREET SIGNAGE**. He tracked down the embossed, black-on-white lettering used citywide from 1946 into the early 1950s, and painstakingly recreated it as a digital typeface. His work gives us a glimpse into the typographic past that shapes the streets we still walk.

Lastly, I want to thank Jac Resnik for being patient as hell, endlessly creative, and the hardest working editor I've ever had the privilege of working with. Her tenacity and her drive to get this herculean effort across the finish line are awe-inspiring. *COMMUNITY* is Jac's brainchild, and nothing you're reading here (except this) would exist without her. When we first started this magazine, I told her I was illiterate and wouldn't read a word she put on the page, but I promised I'd make it look pretty. I hope I've kept that promise to you, reader.

When we started edition three (my second with Jac) she told me she wanted to expand; what you're holding is nearly three times the content of our last issue. I thought this one would be easy to knock out. Instead, I've spent more time on it than any magazine I've ever made, and I honestly couldn't be more proud of our work. I didn't think Jac could pull off the sheer quantity of content it would take to get this thing perfect bound. I was wrong, by a mile. She wrote, wrangled, and edited the biggest magazine I've ever put together, and made it look easy. Between her editorial prowess, my design, and the stories, art, and photography from our contributors, I hope you find in these pages a portrait fit for the city we love.

See you on the train, San Francisco,

Jack Sloop

Designer-in-chief



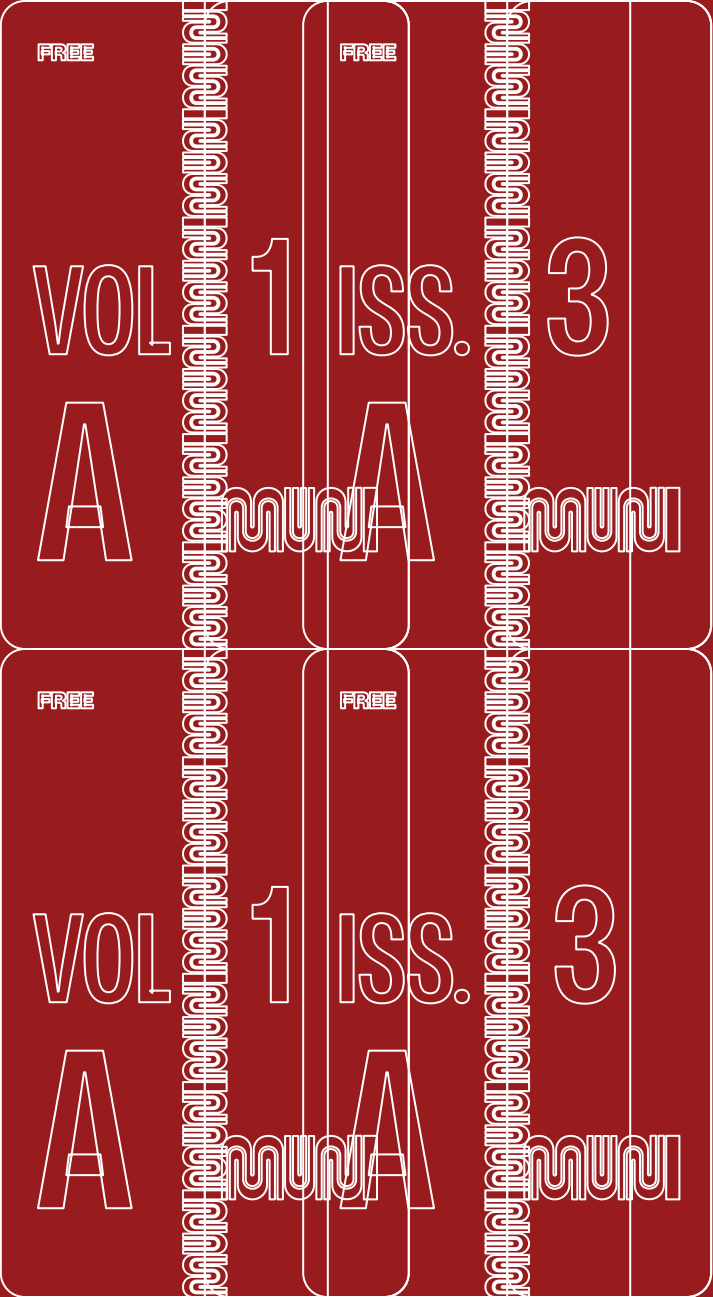


TABLE
of
CONTENTS

<i>Muni, Mixed</i>	14
<i>Dear Driver</i>	18
<i>Muni Matters: Breaking Down Ballot Measures</i>	22
<i>In Conversation with Cat Carter</i>	26
<i>Behind the Scenes Designing Fran Sans</i>	30
<i>Taken with Transportation: Muni Kids</i>	34
<i>Memories From a Morning Commute</i>	36
<i>Muni Etiquette 101: The Backpack Debacle</i>	42
<i>When Transit Wins: Lessons from the World Cup</i>	46
<i>The Many Moods of San Francisco Bus Stops</i>	48
<i>The Quiet Ride Home: Mapping What Riders Carry in Silence</i>	56
<i>Muni Is My Ride Feature: Meet Alex Rodriguez</i>	62
<i>Transit First Policy Review: Where Are We Now</i>	66
<i>Shipwrecks, Sazeracs, and Streetcars: F-Line Bar Crawl</i>	70
<i>Tap on, Cross Off: Muni Bingo</i>	72
<i>Creatures of Muni</i>	74



MUNI, MIXED

PLAYLIST CURATED BY
@UNCLE.ROBOT



Bay Area tunes curated for your next Muni trip, for the days you want to stare out your window and romanticize your life.

All you have to do is grab your headphones and hit play. Your Muni operator will take care of the rest.

“I’M GOING TO CLIMB NOB HILL...”

Turn tracks 1-4 up as you dress up like you’re the most important person in the room. Prepare for a night out, where you can relish all the beauty of “old San Francisco” (and remember this moment the next time someone tries to tell you SF is dead). Climb through the city on a cable car and find yourself at the newly reopened Huntington Hotel. Or, jump on the 7 to Zam Zam for a 50/50 martini.

- TRACK 1: (I LEFT MY HEART) IN SAN FRANCISCO, TONY BENNETT
- TRACK 2: I’M ALWAYS DRUNK IN SAN FRANCISCO, CARMEN MCRAE
- TRACK 3: SAN FRANCISCO, JUDY GARLAND
- TRACK 4: SAN FRANCISCO BLUES, PEGGY LEE

“THERE’S A FOG UPON THE CITY...”

Despite the name of track 5, we’re not sending you to the Mission (yet).

For a peak listening experience of tracks 5-8, grab your tote bag and your biggest sweater. Take the 5 down Fulton and get off somewhere, anywhere in Golden Gate Park. You can’t go wrong. Take a deep breath in and absorb the magnitude of the trees; the friend groups spread out over shared blankets; the elementary school kids hanging around soccer nets. Eventually, find yourself in the Inner Richmond and grab some dumplings. Note the fog, and how it pairs perfectly with the melancholic tunes.

- TRACK 5: MISSION IN THE RAIN, JERRY GARCIA
- TRACK 6: SAN FRANCISCAN NIGHTS, ERIC BURDON & THE ANIMALS
- TRACK 7: SAN FRANCISCO (BE SURE TO WEAR SOME FLOWERS IN YOUR HAIR), SCOTT MCKENZIE
- TRACK 8: HONEYMOON IN SAN FRANCISCO, OF MONTREAL



PHOTO CREDIT:
SFMTA PHOTO ARCHIVE

“ON A WARM SAN FRANCISCO NIGHT...”

Okay, now we’re sending you to the Mission. Grab the J and let tracks 9-12 serve as the soundtrack to your walk through neighborhood. Thumb through records, try on the oversized denim jacket with patches that have better backstories than your 70-year-old neighbors in the Haight. And we beg you, stay out a little longer than you planned, because with Muni, you have a guaranteed ride home.

- **TRACK 9: LIGHTS, JOURNEY**
- **TRACK 10: SAN FRANCISCO KNIGHTS, PEOPLE UNDER THE STAIRS**
- **TRACK 11: FAKE TALES OF SAN FRANCISCO, ARCTIC MONKEYS**
- **TRACK 12: SAN FRANCISCO, THE MONGLI’S**

“UP IN SAN FRANCISCO WHERE THE FOREST MEETS THE BRIDGE...””

Catch the 43, and watch the city open up before your eyes. Grab whatever rail or handle you can as you lean over to open the window, sniff the eucalyptus, catch your first glimpse of the Bridge. Give yourself permission to get lost in reverie as your steady Muni operator winds through the Presidio. May this serve as our collective reminder that we are intensely lucky to live here, and even luckier that we get these views from a bus.

- **TRACK 13: PIAZZA, NEW YORK CATCHER, BELLE AND SEBASTIAN**
- **TRACK 14: SAN FRANCISCO, FOXYGEN**
- **TRACK 15: MOVE TO SAN FRANCISCO, CIRCA WAVES**

“THAT’S WHERE THE HAPPY PEOPLE GO.”

Now is the time to dial it up. Disco belongs here and together we can take back the dance floor. Take the 12, take the 14, take the 49, take the M. Wherever you go, remember there’s no better feeling than hopping on a bus or train with a sea of people who feel that truth in their bones. Catch some newly 21-year-olds exchange glib jokes after pregaming a little too hard before their bus ride.

Find the darkest, deepest room you can and dance your little heart out. You have nowhere else to be.

- **TRACK 16: GOLDEN GATE GIRL, GOLDEN GATE GIRL**
- **TRACK 17: SAN FRANCISCO (YOU’VE GOT ME), VILLAGE PEOPLE**
- **TRACK 18: DISCO SNAILS, VULFON, ZACHARY BAKER**
- **TRACK 19: SAN FRANDISCO, DOM DOLLA**

PHOTO CREDIT:
SFMTA PHOTO ARCHIVE





DEAR DRIVER...

LOVE LETTERS TO OUR FAVORITE MUNI OPERATORS

Dear Driver,

To the 5 Fulton operator who reminded me (along with half of the bus) to step up!! from the back door, thus initiating me into the ranks of San Francisco bus riders, many years ago...

To the J Church operator who calmly stopped the train when a bunch of high schoolers hotboxed a car on the way to Dolores Park, asking them to please get off for our safety...

To the California cable car line operator who delighted in telling my out-of-town friends where to stand for the best views and photo ops as we rumbled through Chinatown...

To the 24 Divisadero operator who sternly barked "you gotta pick that up!" when a bag of recyclables exploded and sent bottles rolling across the floor every time the bus scaled a new hill...

To the gracious operator of the last Breda train who smiled and waved for cameras as we all documented our last ride on the now-retired light-rail model...

...And to all the operators who kept their cool, who showed us how to be good transit riders, and who got us where we needed to go, despite the strangest obstacles, thank you!

Signed,
A proud Muni rider since 2012

Dear Driver,

Once, on a slow weekday morning, you saw me hustling up the hill on Bosworth Street on my way to the Glen Park BART station and slowed your 23 Monterey bus—in between stops—to ask if I wanted to hop on. Had you seen me on your route before and knew where I was headed? Or did I just look like I was having a particularly hard time getting myself to my destination that morning? Either way, I gratefully boarded at the front, you waved off my Clipper card, and motioned for me to have a seat.

Two quick stops later, at Diamond and Bosworth, a procession of backpack-wearing commuters shuffled to the doors and you warmly wished each one a great day as they stepped off your bus. As I exited from the front, I attempted to express my appreciation with my hands pressed together in gratitude and an overly enthusiastic *Thank you!* You replied, "No problem, you have a wonderful day now."

Driver, you made my morning. My whole day, in fact. And now, whenever I'm walking the same route to the BART station, as I climb that small hill on Bosworth Street, I think of you and your random act of kindness. Thank you, saintly driver of the 23 Monterey. Wherever you are, I hope you're having a wonderful day.

Signed,
A fan in Bernal Heights

PHOTO CREDIT:
SFMTA PHOTO ARCHIVE



Dear Driver,

From my window, I can see the yellow-painted pole that marks the number 33 bus line. There it stops, right before it makes its way up the hill and past Buena Vista, down to the Mission and directly to my office. You'd think that means that I can perfectly time my exit in the morning, but in order to make it from my door to the quickly closing door of the bus, I need to sprint down two flights of stairs and across two intersections. By which time, the bus is already on its merry way. And yet, if I quickly change course and sprint up the Ashbury Heights hill as furiously as I can, there's a good chance that you, dear bus driver, will stop just long enough for me to hop on. You don't have to. I snoozed my alarm and luxuriated for a bit too long in the shower's steam. I should have been quicker, more organized. I should have put my keys in the bowl where they go, instead of the pocket of yesterday's pants. I don't deserve a second chance (is it really a second chance if it happens once a week?) but you give it to me.

But that's only the start. Dear 33 bus driver, your job is not over. You still have to execute the turn. You know the one, the perfectly thread needle between Clayton and Market. A sweeping switchback across six lanes, the bus hemmed in by concrete walls like a barge navigating a canal. Its hulking body seems to move more sideways than forwards as it pivots around a center described by the yellow poles that cannot, under any circumstances, detach.

I've ridden this turn so many times that it's dulled from novelty theme park ride to humdrum commute. But sometimes I glance around at the passengers scrolling through OOTDs on TikTok and I can't help but wonder, where's the fanfare, the applause, the awe? We've just watched an Olympic diver splashlessly enter the water, and we're yawning?

So let this be my love letter to you, steward of the 33. You and your daily miracles.

Signed,

A dedicated 33 rider

PHOTO CREDIT:
SFMTA PHOTO ARCHIVE



MUNI MATTERS

BREAKING DOWN THE BALLOT MEASURES THAT WILL MOVE MUNI FORWARD IN NOVEMBER

- DYLAN FABRIS

WHY SHOULD I CARE?

Muni, BART, Caltrain, and AC Transit are all facing major budget deficits starting later this year. If left unaddressed, SFMTA would have to cut 50% of Muni service, reduce fare discounts, stop historic streetcar service, eliminate entire lines, and more. BART would be reduced to one train per hour and forced to close nine stations and two of their five lines. Caltrain would reduce frequency and cut weekend and evening service. AC Transit would have to cut back 37% of its service.

But in November voters will have a chance to say “NO” to transit cuts and “YES” to keeping transit rolling. Two critical measures will be on the ballot, and both will need to pass in order to fill Muni’s budget deficit.

PHOTO CREDIT:
JACK SLOOP

**I. PROP RTM: REGIONAL
TRANSPORTATION MEASURE**

1: WHAT IS IT?

A regional sales tax to benefit public transit in San Francisco, San Mateo, Santa Clara, Alameda, and Contra Costa counties. To help fill Muni's deficit, San Francisco will be taxed at a rate of 1% while the other counties will pay 0.5%.

**2: WHY A SALES TAX? WHY
THESE RATES?**

The regional sales tax was approved by the state legislature last year following months of negotiations with legislators, city and county officials, advocacy groups, business interests, and more. San Francisco currently pays the lowest total sales tax rate compared to the rest of the counties in the measure, so the rate for San Francisco is larger to help fill more of Muni's budget deficit. Most of the tax revenue generated in San Francisco will go to BART and Muni.

**II. PROP H: STRONGER MUNI
FOR ALL**

1: WHAT IS IT?

A "variable rate" parcel tax based on building square footage and usage so larger buildings and commercial buildings pay more.

**2: WHY A VARIABLE RATE
PARCEL TAX?**

California's Prop 13 (from 1978) restricts the use of taxes based on property value. Instead, many cities use variable rate parcel taxes based on square footage so large buildings like downtown skyscrapers pay their fair share. If passed, this will be SF's most progressive parcel tax ever. Other types of taxes like a tax on ride-hail companies were considered but would not have brought in the amount of revenue needed to fill Muni's large budget deficit.



HOW TO GET INVOLVED:

1: STAY IN THE LOOP.

In San Francisco, sign up for updates from San Francisco Transit Riders at SFTransitRiders.org. If you are located outside of San Francisco, look up organizations like Seamless Bay Area and Transbay Coalition, which are mobilizing volunteers to support the regional measure.

2: HELP GET OUT THE VOTE!

Educate your friends, neighbors, and merchants. It's never too early to start talking about why these measures are important. Talk to your friends and family about why you will be voting to fund transit this year. Talk to your neighbors and local businesses about why transit is important and how service cuts would affect your community. If you work with an organization or a business, have them join the Muni Now, Muni Forever coalition at MuniForever.org.

For more information on both the transit measures, and to access all of SF Transit Riders' election information, visit sftr.link/vote

PHOTO CREDIT:
JACK SLOOP





WHAT HAPPENS IF WE DON'T PASS THIS?

IN CONVERSATION WITH CAT CARTER

- JAC HATTER RESNIK

Picture BART with entire stations shuttered. Caltrain going dark on weekends and stopping its clocks at 9 p.m. Muni service cut nearly in half, leaving neighborhoods with buses that come once an hour instead of every ten minutes.

We've moved beyond hypotheticals here. If Measure RTM (the Regional Transit Measure) — a five county regional measure built to raise new, sustainable funding for public transit — fails to pass, these possibilities could soon become our realities.

For years, transit agencies across the region have survived on a patchwork of funding sources, propped up by whatever money happened to be available at the moment. Emergency federal funding carried agencies through the pandemic, but that well has run dry. As Cat Carter, one of the campaign's organizers, puts it: "We've kicked the can down the road. We are at the end of the road, and if we don't pass this funding, we will be facing absolutely devastating cuts, especially on Muni, BART, Caltrain, and AC Transit."

Cat's connection to transit started young, riding the T through Boston as a teenager to get to all-ages punk shows, explore the urban landscape, and escape the suburbs for a few hours. That early sense of freedom shaped a lifelong belief that transit is essential to city life, and cemented her as a dedicated transit advocate. For Cat, that advocacy extends far beyond getting buses and trains from one destination to the next. Cat harkens back to a streetcar ride in Amsterdam. The driver's booth doubled as a place to ask for directions and quietly keep the space comfortable for everyone on board, a model that reframes fare enforcement as something closer to hosting. She also pays attention to smaller, tangible ways to make our systems better, like clearer signage, intuitive maps, and communications around the enormous number of people and cars a single bus can move. She knows those details can help make transit legible, welcoming, and connected to the people who use it every day.

A good transit advocate recognizes that our transit systems are only as good as the planning around it. "When I see a traffic jam, like the daily approach to the bridge to get out of town, that, to me, is not a traffic jam so much as a failure of regional transportation planning," says Cat.

PHOTO CREDIT:
JOSE ALVAREZ

That failure hits everyone, even those who have never stepped foot on transit. Every rider without reliable transit options is one more car on the road, one more reason the drivers around them are sitting in traffic too. A well funded transit system is the release valve for the whole road network, and the cuts on the table without the Regional Transit Measure would push even more people into cars, tightening congestion for everyone regardless of how they get around.

The volunteers behind the Regional Transit Measure aren't going to let that happen without a fight. Getting the measure to this point has taken an enormous grassroots effort. Volunteers across the region have had more than 100,000 conversations with voters, and the advocates' campaign gathered over 77,000 signatures, more than doubling its original goal. That kind of organizing matters. These volunteers have brought a deep knowledge of their neighborhoods, firsthand accounts of what a ride on specific bus lines feels like, and a true stake in the future of regional transit.

“If public transit is such an essential good in a society, to provide mobility, to address climate change, it’s community building. Can we switch our mindset from ‘you must pay to ride’ to ‘we want everybody to ride it’?”

Misconceptions have surfaced along the way, especially around fare evasion and agency efficiency. Reports suggest Muni and BART actually run fairly efficiently compared to their counterparts nationally, and fare evasion losses (while real) amount to a small fraction of the funding shortfall the region is facing.

For Cat, the larger question is how we think about public transit in the first place. “If public transit is such an essential good in a society, to provide mobility, to address climate change, it’s community building. Can we switch our mindset from ‘you must pay to ride’ to ‘we want everybody to ride it’?”

That idea runs through Cat's vision for better transit: making the system easier to understand, more welcoming to riders, and more visibly connected to the communities it serves. It can mean a driver who helps someone find their way; a bus shelter that makes it easy to see how far the next bus is, regardless of the angle you approach the stop from; a map that all riders can easily digest. Small solutions can transform how people experience a system, and in turn, how much they're willing to adopt it.

None of this happens without political power built from the ground up. Campaigns like the Regional Transit Measure exist because advocates spent years showing up, organizing, and pushing agencies to listen, work that has slowly started to change the tone between riders and the officials who serve them. The measure won't fix everything on its own, but it stabilizes the foundation transit needs in order to grow from here.

PHOTO CREDIT:
JOSE ALVAREZ





BEHIND THE SCENES DESIGNING FRAN SANS A TYPEFACE BORN FROM MUNI'S DISAPPEARING SIGNS

— EMILY SNEDDON

Fran Sans is a display font in every sense of the term. It's an interpretation of the destination displays found on some of the light rail vehicles that service the city of San Francisco.

I say some because destination displays aren't consistently used across the city's transit system. In fact, SF has an unusually high number of independent public transit agencies. Unlike New York, Chicago or L.A., which each have one, maybe two, San Francisco and the greater Bay Area have over two dozen. Each agency, with its own models of buses and trains, use different destination displays, creating an eclectic patchwork of typography across the city.

Among them, one display in particular has always stood out to me: the LCD panel displays inside Muni's Breda Light Rail Vehicles. I remember first noticing them on a Saturday in October on the N-Judah, heading to the Outer Sunset for a shrimp hoagie. This context is important, as anyone who's spent an October weekend in SF knows this is the optimal vibe to really take in the beauty of the city.

What caught my eye was how the displays look mechanical and yet distinctly personal. Constructed on a 3x5 grid, the characters are made up of geometric modules: squares, quarter-circles, and angled forms. Combined, these modules create imperfect, almost primitive letterforms, revealing a utility and charm that feels distinctly like the San Francisco I've come to know.

This balance of utility and charm seems to show up everywhere in San Francisco and its history. The Golden Gate's "International Orange" started as nothing more than a rust-proof primer, yet is now the city's defining colour. The Painted Ladies became multicoloured icons after the 1960s Colourist movement covered decades of grey paint. Even the steepness of the streets was once an oversight in city planning but has since been romanticised in films and on postcards. So perhaps it is unsurprising that I would find this same utility and charm in a place as small and functional as a train sign.

Editor's Note:

There are a handful of things I've come to believe about the people who love this city the way we do: we notice things other people walk past. We catch the mural going up on a boarded-up storefront before anyone else mentions it. We look up. And every so often, we meet someone else who notices too, someone who's been staring at the same glowing little sign on the same train car we've ridden a thousand times, except they saw something in it we never did.

That's exactly what happened when Emily Sneddon brought us Fran Sans.

Emily looked at the LCD destination display inside Muni's Breda light rail cars (RIP), the same flickering, slightly clunky sign most of us have glanced at without a second thought on our way to Ocean Beach or to Dolores. But she saw a whole alphabet worth saving, studying, tracing, and rebuilding letter by letter into something new. That kind of attention, the kind that turns a transit sign most people would call a fixture into something worth loving on purpose, is exactly the kind of San Francisco story we started this magazine to tell.

So, thank you, Emily, for letting us feature Fran Sans in these pages. Thank you for reminding us that even the smallest, most utilitarian corners of this city, the ones we take completely for granted, are quietly full of character, if we just take the time to look. We're lucky to know people who care about transit and this city as much as we do, and luckier still when they're willing to share it with the rest of us.

Enjoy the piece. I certainly did.



ALL ART AND PHOTOGRAPHY
COURTESY OF EMILY SNEDDON

To learn more about these displays, I visited the San Francisco Municipal Transportation Agency’s (SFMTA) Electronics Shop at Balboa Park. There, technician Armando Lumbad had set up one of the signs. They each feature one large LCD panel which displays the line name, and twenty-four smaller ones to display the destination. The loose spacing of the letters and fluorescent backlighting gives the sign a raw, analogue quality. Modern LED dot-matrix displays are far more efficient and flexible, but to me, they lack the awkwardness that makes these Breda signs so delightful.

Armando showed me how the signs work. He handed me a printed matrix table listing every line and destination, each paired with a three-digit code. On route, train operators punch the code into a control panel at the back of the display, and the LCD blocks light on specific segments of the grid to build each letter. I picked code 119, and Armando entered it for me. A few seconds later the panels revealed my own stop: the **N-JUDAH** at **CHURCH & DUBOCE**. There in the workshop, devoid of the context of the trains and the commute, the display looked almost monolithic, or sculptural, and I have since fantasised whether it would be possible to ship one of these home to Australia.

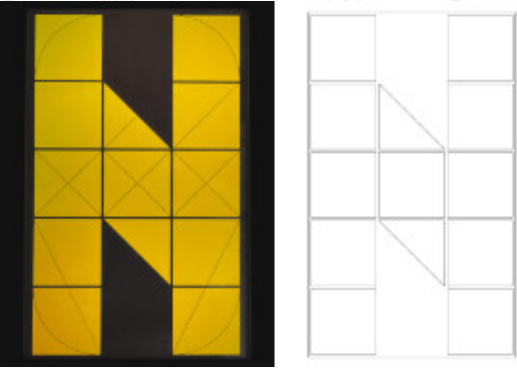
Looking inside of the display, I found labels identifying the make and model. The signs were designed and manufactured by Trans-Lite, Inc., a company based in Milford, Connecticut that specialised in transport signage from 1959 until its acquisition by the Nordic firm Teknoware in 2012. After lots of amateur detective work, and with the help from an anonymous Reddit user in a Connecticut community group, I was connected with Gary Wallberg, Senior Engineer at Trans-Lite and the person responsible for the design of these very signs back in 1999.

Learning that the alphabet came from an engineer really explains its temperament and why I was drawn to it in the first place. The signs were designed for sufficiency: fixed segments, fixed grid, and no extras. Characters were created only as destinations required them, while other characters, like the Q, X, and much of the punctuation, were never programmed into the signs. In reducing everything to its bare essentials, somehow character emerged, and it’s what inspired me to design Fran Sans.

I shared some initial drawings with Dave Foster of Foster Type who encouraged me to get the font software Glyphs and turn it into my first working font. From there, I broke down the anatomy of the letters into modules, then used them like Lego to build out a full set: uppercase A–Z, numerals, core punctuation.

Some glyphs remain unsolved in this first version, for example the standard @ symbol refuses to squeeze politely into the 3x5 logic. Lowercase remains a question for the future, and would likely mean reconsidering the grid. But, as with the displays themselves, I am judging Fran Sans as sufficient for now.

Grid comparison. Left is a photo of the display, right is Fran Sans.



Getting up close to these signs, you’ll notice Fran Sans’ gridlines are simplified even from its real-life muse, but my hope is that its character remains. Specifically: the **N(H)** and the zero (**0**), where the unusually thick diagonals close in on the counters; and the **Z(Z)** and **7(7)**, whose diagonals can feel uncomfortably thin. I’ve also noticed the centre of the **M(H)** can scale strangely and read like an **H(H)** at small sizes, but in fairness, this type was never designed for the kind of technical detail so many monospaced fonts aim for. Throughout the process I tried to protect these unorthodox moments, because to me, they determined the success of this interpretation.

Fran Sans comes in three styles: **SOLID**, **TILE**, and **GRID**, each building in visual complexity. The decision to include variations, particularly the Solid style, was inspired by my time working at Christopher Doyle & Co. There, we worked with Bell Shakespeare, Australia’s national theatre company dedicated to the works of William Shakespeare. The equity of the Bell Shakespeare brand lies in its typography, which is a beautiful custom typeface called Hotspur, designed and produced by none other than Dave Foster.

Often, brand fonts are chosen or designed to convey a single feeling. Maybe it’s warmth and friendliness, or a sense of tech and innovation. But what I’ve always loved about the Bell typeface is how one weight could serve both Shakespeare’s comedies and tragedies, simply by shifting scale, spacing, or alignment. Hotspur has the gravity to carry the darkness of Titus Andronicus and the roundness to convey the humour of Much Ado About Nothing. And while **FRAN SANS SOLID** is technically no Hotspur, I wanted it to share that same versatility.

Further inspiration for **FRAN SANS** came from the Letterform Archive, the world’s leading typography archive, based in San Francisco. Librarian and archivist Kate Long Stellar thoughtfully curated a research visit filled with modular typography spanning most of the past century. On the table were two pieces that had a significant impact on **FRAN SANS** and are now personal must-sees at the archive. First, Joan Trochut’s Tipo Veloz “Fast Type” (1942) was created during the Second World War when resources were scarce. Tipo Veloz gave printers the ability to draw with type, rearranging modular pieces to form letters, ornaments and even illustrations.

Second, Zuzana Licko’s process work for Lo-Res (1985), an Emigre typeface, opened new ways of thinking about how ideas move between the physical and the digital and then back again. Seeing how Lo-Res was documented through iterations and variations gave the typeface a depth and richness that changed my understanding of how fonts are built. At some point I want to explore physical applications for **FRAN SANS** out of respect for its origins, since it is impossible to fully capture the display’s charm on screen.

Back at the SFMTA, Armando told me the Breda vehicles are being replaced, and with them their destination displays will be swapped for newer LED dot-matrix units that are more efficient and easier to maintain. By the end of 2025 the signs that inspired **FRAN SANS** will disappear from the city, taking with them a small but distinctive part of the city’s voice. That feels like a real loss. San Francisco is always reinventing itself, yet its charm lies in how much of its history still shows through. My hope is that **FRAN SANS** can inspire a deeper appreciation for the imperfections that give our lives and our cities character. Life is so rich when ease and efficiency are not the measure.

For commercial and non-commercial use of **FRAN SANS**, reach out to Emily Sneddon at emily@emilysneddon.com

JUDAH
IRVING
CARL
DUBOCE
CHURCH
VAN NESS
CIVIC CENTER
POWELL
MONTGOMERY
EMBARCADERO



TAKEN WITH TRANSPORTATION: MUNI KIDS

- MELISSA CULROSS

Have you had a chance to check out Taken with Transportation? It's the San Francisco Municipal Transportation Agency's official podcast. Hop along for the ride as the episodes cover everything from the city's streets to the inner workings of Muni. These stories offer perspectives you won't get anywhere else and insight into the passion that fuels the SFMTA's work.

The latest episode, "Muni Kids," is about the creation and evolution of the agency's popular Free Muni for Youth program. Today, all young people 18 and under ride Muni for free (with the exception of the cable cars), but that hasn't always been the case. The episode examines how the program came to be and why it's important for San Francisco. You can find "Muni Kids" at [SFMTA.com/Podcast](https://sfmta.com/Podcast), Apple Podcasts, Spotify or wherever you listen.

ABOUT THE HOST

Melissa Culross comes to the SFMTA from the broadcasting industry where she spent three decades on the air at radio stations in San Francisco and in New England. Melissa also has been a regular Muni rider since moving to the city in the 1990s.



PHOTO CREDIT:
SFMTA PHOTO ARCHIVE





MEMORIES FROM A MORNING COMMUTE

- NIKKI COLLISTER

Sometime in 2017 or 2018, I wrote this little chronicle of my daily commute. I thought I might look back on it later and appreciate the forgotten details of the hour-long journey from the Outer Richmond to the Mission. Then I tucked it away in a text editor on my computer and forgot about it.

Now it's many years later and the intended nostalgia has come much sooner than expected. My job went remote in March 2020, and since then I've never gone back to the office full-time. And though I like the flexibility of remote work, I find myself missing the mundane familiarity of a commute, traveling through a dozen different neighborhoods every morning and evening, my daily dose of city life.

Since I doubt I'll ever get that back (and if I do, it won't be this specific commute), I wanted to document it here as a small tribute to the routes my fellow San Franciscans and I once shared.

PHOTO CREDIT:
JOSE ALVAREZ



8:05

From outside my apartment building at 29th and Anza, I can see across the entire city. Low clouds hang in the sky, wrapping the hills in a cool embrace, painting the morning landscape in washed out hues. In the distance stand the silhouettes of Downtown: 555 California looking like a monolith, the Transamerica Pyramid poking through a sea of shadowy rooftops, Salesforce Tower presiding over it all. That's where I'm headed, but it's not my destination.

8:08

I'm wearing my ankle-high boots today, the ones that give me an extra inch of height and make me feel slightly more badass when they click-clack down the sidewalk. Each step cuts through the sleepy morning haze as I descend the hill eastward, past the school kids trudging up to George Washington High School.

I click-clack past apartment buildings on corners and single family homes in between, the Richmond District fog clinging to my black raincoat. As a resident of the avenues, the raincoat is my default outer layer, not because it really rains that much, it just mists.

8:11

I time my walk so that I arrive at 25th and Geary just as the 38AX pulls up to the curb. On more frantic days, I might see the bus rolling through the intersection when I'm still halfway down 26th Ave., causing me to go into overdrive, feet pounding down the sidewalk and around the corner of Enchante Cafe, waving a hand in the air so that a boarding passenger might see me and hold the door (usually they do).

Although there are several bus stops closer to my apartment, 25th Ave. is the best option because it's where all variations of the 38 Geary stop: the regular 38 with its accordion middle and mostly elderly passengers; its slightly faster and more crowded counterpart the 38-R; and the two express buses, the 38AX and 38BX. All of them go downtown, but the express buses pick up their last riders in the suburbs of the Richmond and don't open their doors again until reaching the heart of the Financial District. The express buses are the commuter's best option.

The 38AX, one of the older models that's all 90 degree angles instead of smooth curves like its modern successors, lets out a sigh of exhaust as its doors open. We step on in an orderly fashion, holding our Clipper cards to the machine until it beeps in recognition.

8:15

The front rows of the bus face inwards, giving more space to people standing in the aisle during rush hour. Near the back, seats are arranged in twos, facing forward. The very last row seats five across, and this is where I claim my spot, pulling my backpack to my lap and hugging it so I take up the least amount of space possible. From my plastic seat in the center of the last row, I have a direct line of sight to every person on the bus.

There's a woman near the front putting on mascara, balancing her purse on her lap and a handheld mirror in her other hand. Next to the woman sits a young father with a tiny baby strapped to his chest. His eyes are closed, the baby's are wide open. A man and woman sit in one of the two-seaters to my right; I'd guess they're in their mid- to late-30s. She's wearing low heels and a silk shirt, the way most FiDi-bound women dress. He's in shorts, a t-shirt, and a "straight out of Lagunitas" hat. They talk like old friends. He scratches his beard and shows her a photo on his phone; she smiles and laughs. The aroma of her hairspray tickles my nose.

Their conversation is rare on a bus mostly full of silent commuters. Almost everyone else is in their own world, headphones plugged in, reading books, playing games on tiny screens.

8:20

The bus chugs through 36 more intersections—passing the bakeries and sleepy corner bars, the Geary Parkway Motel and the Taco Bell-KFC, the funeral home and the pet store and the Mattress Firm—until it rounds the corner from Geary to Presidio, revealing a sweeping panoramic view of the city. Sunshine is starting to break through the clouds downtown.

Now that we're out of the avenues, we're flying down Bush St., hitting all the green lights. We glide past the dog-walkers and yoga practitioners of Lower Pac Heights, the patchwork of Victorian houses and mid-century housing in the Western Addition, before crossing Van Ness Ave., the unofficial gateway between the residential and the commercial. On the streets of Nob Hill, construction workers take their breaks, business owners sweep their doorsteps, cleaners lug their vacuums down stairs...all these people whose day started long ago. A doorman stands statuesque outside a hotel, like the eye of a hurricane.

8:30

Just past Grant Ave., the colorful throngs of Chinatown — with its windows full of statues and chandeliers and intricately painted ceramics — give way to the buttoned-up bustle of downtown, where suits and skirts coexist with hoodies and Allbirds.

After the exhilarating rush of Bush Street, the bus driver pumps the brakes as we merge into the flow of downtown traffic, a sea of grey and red Muni buses, delivery trucks, cars, and ride shares, all moving in unison among the shadows of skyscrapers.

8:37

The woman in the front of the bus has just finished applying her coral lipstick and tips a small bottle of perfume on each of her wrists, completing a transformation I can tell she has perfected over many commutes. I remember witnessing a similar ritual on the traffic-clogged highways in LA, women leaning into their car mirrors while sweeping eyeliner across their lids, occasionally peering around to see if the cars in front of them had moved. Here we've traded traffic for transit, content to paint our faces in the company of strangers, grateful we don't have to monitor the traffic ahead. We gather our things and prepare to exit our comfortable steel cocoon.

8:40

The bus deposits us at Bush and Sansome. I join the crowd of people speed walking down the sidewalk, hardly giving a second glance at the robot barista serving espressos on the corner.

At the intersection of Sansome and Sutter, everyone stands waiting at opposite ends of the crosswalk, hands in coat pockets, staring ahead like warriors about to step into battle. When the light changes, we all step off the sidewalk at exactly the same time, two walls of people meeting in the middle of the street.

Steam rises from manholes, cloaking the surface of Market Street in a pulsating shroud.

8:43

The soundscape of Montgomery Station as I step down the stairs: David Byrne's fall playlist in my ears, synthesizer-heavy pop melting into an accordion version of "Over the Rainbow," as performed by a busker in the corridor leading to the BART entrance. My boots join the steady rhythm of heels on stained tile, the same floor that people often sleep on, covered in blankets that are too small. An occasional voice pierces above it all, sometimes shouting conspiracy theories to no one in particular, sometimes shouting the day's schedules into a phone.

In front of me, an old couple shuffles toward the BART turnstile. Instead of continuing at the same pace and cutting around them as I usually find myself doing, I hang back, at some level wanting to make sure they get through ok. He procures a ticket and hands it to her, guiding her to the gate. One by one, they pass through.

The heavy ka-thunk of the turnstile is satisfying as I scan my Clipper card (inevitably there's always one out of order). As I descend on the escalator, the electric whirl of the Muni on the second level crossfades into the harsh screech of a BART train pulling onto the platform.

8 : 45

On the mosaic-inlaid benches on the BART platform sit a potpourri of humans: tech workers on their computers, students reading books, people without a home stretched out next to their belongings.

A wave of commuters shuffle out of the Daly City-bound train, phones in hand. At this point I'm going against the traffic, but the car is still crowded enough to necessitate standing. I wait my turn to enter, then take my place near the rear door. A hand grips the hanging handle in front of me, fingernails painted dark purple.

My hand grips the handle in front of me, fingernails painted dark purple. I feel the car lurch forward, the wheels hitting a pothole. I look out the window, seeing the city streets blur past. The car is still crowded enough to necessitate standing. I wait my turn to enter, then take my place near the rear door.

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The Jimmy Carter lookalike is on my train again, reading the paper. He's wearing a red jacket, white hair piled on top of his head. Does Jimmy Carter wear thick-soled trainers like this man? I assume he must, at his age. The lookalike sits next to the door, calmly turning over the newspaper. He always has this serene look about him.

There's a woman sitting next to him, looking a little nervous. She clutches a tote bag with the words "Talk curdy to me" printed on it, accompanying a drawing of cows. I want to tell her I like her bag, but I won't.

I want to tell her I like her bag, but I won't. The car lurches forward, the wheels hitting a pothole. I look out the window, seeing the city streets blur past. The car is still crowded enough to necessitate standing. I wait my turn to enter, then take my place near the rear door.

8 : 55

Jimmy Carter gets off at the 16th Street station. I get off one stop after him, at 24th Street.

The man and woman playing Afro-Cuban music are at the east side of the station again, their congas and tambourine panning in and out as I walk by. They're always wearing white, always smiling.

In this station there's a rotating lineup of buskers: the Afro-Cuban musicians, the guy in the baggy sweatshirt playing jittery violin, the blind girl with the shaved head singing a cappella versions of punk rock songs from the mid-2000s. These are usually the people who get my spare change, if I have it.

The escalator is broken. It's been probably four months. I pull myself up the stairs — 60 to be exact — toward the now-blue sky.

9 : 00

I pass by the man who stands next to the parking meter outside La Major bakery with his cane and cigarette every morning. Like clockwork, he smiles from underneath his Fedora and says to me, "Good morning, bonita" and I reply back with a polite "Good morning."

Past the liquor store, the library, the parking lot painted with birds and depictions of Jesus. Across the intersection where pedestrians and bicyclists and tech shuttles meet, narrowly missing each other every time. Pausing outside the market on the corner of Valencia and 24th, smelling the freshly cut oranges.

I dig for my keys as I approach the parklet outside Artamendi. If it's Tuesday, the parklet is deserted. If it's any other day of the week, it's packed with moms and dogs and babies in strollers. Today is Tuesday, and the bakery is closed.

9 : 24

I unlock the deadbolt on the door, checking the time, 59 minutes door-to-door, five miles total, eight more hours until it's time for the same commute in reverse.



ART CREDIT:
CHRISTINE INNES



MUNI ETIQUETTE 101: THE BACKPACK DEBACLE

- LIZ HEYH

It's early. If it were the weekend, you'd be in bed watching hot priest clips from Fleabag on Instagram Reels. But instead, you've got a fuzzy headache right behind your nose, and your hands are snared in the rubber overhead straps of the N. You forgot to take your jacket off before boarding the train, and now muggy pockets of air cling to the crooks of your elbows. Behind you, the mass of commuters undulates, and someone's tech-branded computer bag has found a home in the small of your back. With every jostle of the train, you can feel the zipper against your spine. Your stop can't arrive soon enough.

You should say something, right? Sure, nobody's ever completely comfortable on a commute. And this guy needs to carry his computer to the office somehow. But you really should say something. Right?

Having been on both sides of this interaction—both scolded backpack-wearer and beleaguered backpack victim—I decided to poll my coworkers in order to get to the bottom of the debate.

When standing on a crowded train during commuting hours, where should you put your backpack?

The results were almost perfectly split, and commensurately contentious.

Right off the bat, the scorn for on your back was palpable in the chat, and it was clear that there was no hope for that option. At your feet, despite ultimately winning, fascinatingly lagged behind for hours. In large part because of one vocal coworker concerned about emergency evacuations. Supposing the train needs to empty urgently, how do you do so if the floor is littered with backpacks? My colleague quickly rebutted that on a truly crowded train you accept that emergency evacuation is going to take a while. I'd never seen my coworkers more heated.

Procrastinating work, I eagerly monitored the conversation. As people began to seek evidence for their claims, the votes for at your feet began to creep up. What turned the tide, it seems, was the influx of transit signs from everywhere from SF to Singapore.

Captain Canuck in Backpack Basics!

Bag on the floor makes space for more

Mo' backpacks, mo' problems

PHOTO CREDIT:
JACK SLOOP

The receipts don't lie. It seems that the official advice from almost every transit system is to place your bag at your feet: sticky subway floor be damned.

Back to your commute, the train has turned a bend and the stranger's backpack, thrust into your back, has nearly thrown you to the floor. You've decided to finally say something, and if you want to take a page from my coworker Lindsey's book, you can steal her scathing comment word for word:

Excuse me, would you mind moving your bag towards your feet? It's crushing our bodies.

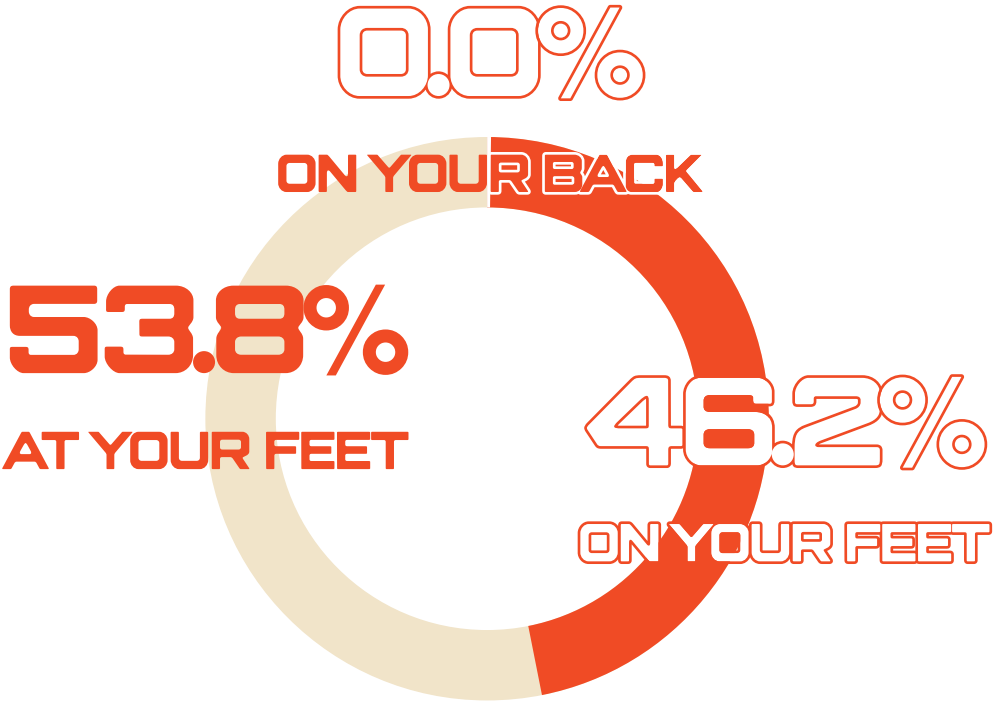


PHOTO CREDIT:
JACK SLOOP



WHEN TRANSIT WINS: LESSONS FROM THE WORLD CUP

- DYLAN RESNIK

When I was lucky enough to receive a last minute call from my father that we had World Cup tickets for a match in Atlanta, there was a mad dash to make arrangements; flights, hotels, a hastily assembled stadium-approved clear bag came together in short time.

Fortunately, one thing we didn't have to think twice about was transit from Jackson Hartsfield, the busiest airport in the world, to the Falcons' football stadium for a match that would bring in nearly 70,000 fans. MARTA's rapid rail system provided us with an easy and affordable way in and out.

Just as the world's best futbol teams were on display over the course of 6 weeks this summer, America's transit systems were too. Visitors from around the world came to explore our cities and expected convenient, safe, and affordable ways to get around. More times than not, local transit exceeded expectations.

None of this happened by accident. Existing systems were bolstered by careful planning and a notable boost in funding. Months before the World Cup, the federal government distributed \$100 million to host cities for this very purpose, another reminder that funding is critical for these systems to run well.

During the tournament, many of the host cities saw record-breaking ridership numbers. MARTA reported 4.7 million rail passenger trips over the course of 35 days. Locally, the VTA in Santa Clara set records of its own. The rest of the Bay Area's transit systems also played an undeniable role in this success.

Personally, I found that public transit didn't just facilitate the event. It enhanced it. Chants began long before we arrived at our destination, anticipation grew, and the energy built up with each new flurry of passengers shuffling through the car doors. The feeling of connection was inescapable. I think about the few unsuspecting travelers who hopped on without prior knowledge of the world they were walking into, but I'd like to think they too came away with a story to share that evening.

I'm grateful to Atlanta's public servants, community organizers, and voters who all came together with a vision for MARTA more than four decades ago. Long before riders ever stepped on a train car, they had the foresight that a regional rail system would benefit so many, from daily commuters to one-off event goers. This is public infrastructure at its best, government at its most effective and impactful.

I hope we continue to hold this vision close, and remember the impact these systems will have both today and in the decades to come, for relying on them daily, and for all the global events we may have the good fortune to host.

PHOTO CREDIT:
SFMTA PHOTO ARCHIVE



PHOTOS ESSAY

THE MANY MOODS OF SAN FRANCISCO BUS STOPS, THROUGHOUT THE DAY

- ZOE HALEN - ORIGINALLY PUBLISHED IN MISSION LOCAL

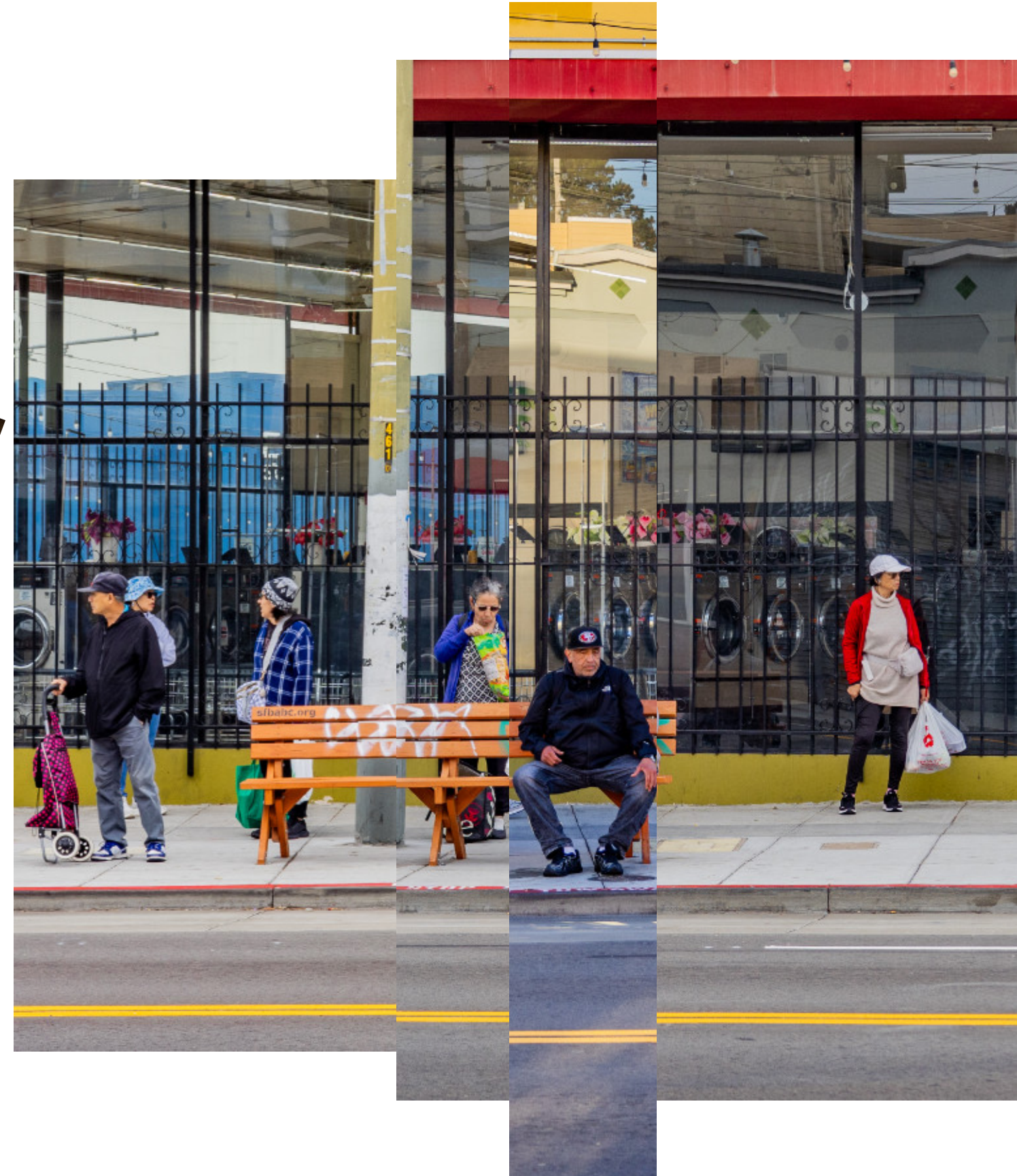
San Francisco has about 3,000 bus stops. A good number are built out with benches covered by trademark undulating, red roofs — locally designed and meant to evoke “a seismic shockwave,” the surf or, perhaps, the Muni logo.

Others have been recently outfitted with wooden benches by a guerrilla outfit that the city, for the most part, appears to tolerate; it counts 26 benches in the city so far. Many more are just marked by yellow paint on a street pole.

Mission Local visited several bus stops in the city at different times of the day: During the morning rush hour, the end-of-day commute, and later at night. We saw crowds grow and thin, city workers power wash sidewalks, and some stops that stayed mostly empty all day.



O'FARRELL & LEAVENWORTH



MISSION & PERSIA



MISSION & 16TH



NINTH & JUDAH







THE QUIET RIDE HOME:

MAPPING WHAT RIDERS CARRY IN SILENCE

*What riders see, and what riders survive,
inside the push for safer Muni*

- JAC HATTER RESNIK

There's a particular kind of quiet that settles over a late-night bus. Fewer people, more space to breathe, the hum of the engine louder than usual. For many riders, that quiet feels like relief after a long night out. For others, it feels like a held breath.

Indigo Rosenberg, creator of the Eyes on Board initiative, knows that feeling intimately. The project was born out of an experience she hopes most riders will never have to think twice about. During her sophomore year of college, Rosenberg was riding an Owl bus home with a group of friends, dressed up, exhausted, and out of money for anything but the bus. A man in the corner of the bus made sure the ride stayed with them. The group went quiet and still, doing the math on what they didn't have — no safe stop to bail out at, no fare for a car, no one to call, and at least thirty minutes until another bus would come. So they rode it out, because riding it out was the only plan available.

That story became the foundation for a much bigger project for Rosenberg. Harassment on transit happens constantly, but it happens quietly, confined to the kind of conversation that only occurs between friends who've learned there's no other way to talk about it without wanting to crawl out of their own skin. Rosenberg's project exists to drag that quiet into the spotlight. An anonymous survey and a live map now track where and how harassment happens across the city's transit system, turning what's long been dismissed as background noise into a public (growing) record.

What distinguishes Rosenberg's approach is how bluntly she ties that record to the transit decisions being made right now. She knows that service cuts can mean more time standing alone at a dark stop, more time trapped on a bus with nowhere else to go, more risk for the riders who already have the least power to protect themselves. Safety and funding, she insists, have to be discussed in the same breath.

For Rosenberg, this all comes back to one, undeniable conviction: "Walkability should not be a luxury, and urbanism should be equitable." That idea runs through everything the project touches, from who gets to move freely through the city to who has to plan their route around avoiding certain streets or certain hours.

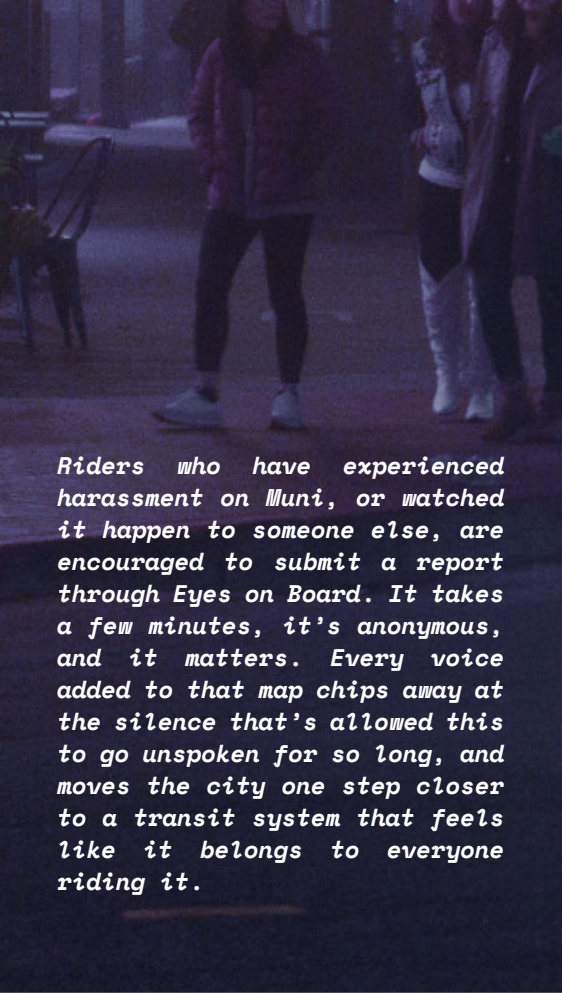
Rosenberg makes it clear that Eyes on Board comes from a place of care for transit. The goal is an honest reckoning with what riders actually experience, and a push toward making the system better for the people who depend on it. Rosenberg hopes the data collected will reach the agencies and campaigns shaping the region's transit future, and that it will remind riders they are not alone in what they've experienced. Solidarity is part of the point. Every report, however small it may feel, adds up to something bigger than any one person's discomfort.

Safety on transit also lives in the infrastructure riders move through every day, long before anything goes wrong.

PHOTO CREDIT:
SFMTA PHOTO ARCHIVE

Anthony Bu has ridden Muni long enough to know exactly where its blind spots are. He points first to stops without boarding islands, where riders have to step off the sidewalk and into traffic just to catch a train or bus. It's "inherently hazardous," says Bu, and a common problem, not a rare one. The L Taraval has recently seen real upgrades, he says, but lines like the M Ocean View and J Church still leave people standing in the street to board. Muni's newer trains now play automated announcements warning riders as they step off, but Bu isn't convinced that solves much. A recorded voice can't stop a speeding car, and it does little for someone who can't see the platform or doesn't speak English. What actually keeps people safe, in his view, is simpler: solid ground between the rider and the road.

Put side by side, Rosenberg's work and Bu's day-to-day observations turn out to be describing the same system, just from different vantage points. There's the threat of harassment. The risk of a boarding stop with no island to stand on. The stickiness of a bus with no working fan. Riders like Bu encounter the physical, environmental layer of that experience daily, in the open. Riders like Rosenberg carry the emotional layer, often alone, often silently. For both of them, the underlying question is the same: whether the system was built with the rider in mind.



Riders who have experienced harassment on Muni, or watched it happen to someone else, are encouraged to submit a report through Eyes on Board. It takes a few minutes, it's anonymous, and it matters. Every voice added to that map chips away at the silence that's allowed this to go unspoken for so long, and moves the city one step closer to a transit system that feels like it belongs to everyone riding it.

PHOTO CREDIT:
ALEX BENJAMIN







MEET ALEX RODRIGUEZ

DUAL QUALIFIED OPERATOR PCC AND LRV, GREEN AND MUNI METRO EAST DIVISIONS

- SPECIAL EXCERPT FROM *MUNI IS MY RIDE*

Alex Rodriguez remembers being fascinated with a photo of a cable car when he was growing up in El Salvador. At the age of twenty-five, as a newly arrived immigrant, he rode his first historic streetcar down Market to Fisherman's Wharf and thought, Look at this old train, it's still in service. His first jobs in San Francisco were driving tour buses and limos, jobs which gave him opportunities to observe cable car drivers up close, and eventually, a thought formed: *Hey, if this person can do it, why can't I?*

Ten years later, with the goal of operating the cable cars, Alex became a Muni bus driver for the Kirkland Division. Among Kirkland's seven lines, he most enjoyed the scenic runs, the 76X Marin Headlands, which crosses the Golden Gate Bridge, and the 43 Masonic, which starts at Fort Mason on the Bay, traverses the city, and ends at Crocker Amazon Park.

"Driving buses, I did have my doubts. No matter that I am very considerate and polite, locals can be very demanding, so there were days I asked myself: *What am I doing here?* But now that I'm on the rails and driving the historic streetcars, I don't feel that way. I am very productive, operating these amazing machines. I transport myself into the story, how in 1906 after the earthquake, the cable car and streetcar lines were the only way to get around. I am in a long line of generations of streetcar drivers, and I am so proud of this."

Alex was four years in when he transferred to the streetcar, or rails, division. "The downside is you cannot make plans for after work, or even breaks. If there's a breakdown, and they average two to three a day, tows take a long time. You can be one block from the garage, and if the train in front of you is stuck, you're stuck, too. If you're on a bus, you can circumvent problems. But not on the rails.

"When I first came to San Francisco, work meant making a living. That's it. A job wasn't something you loved, but Muni helped me find my happy. Now I have a sense that I can do something with my life. My goal is the cable car division, but if that doesn't happen, I'll return to college. There are opportunities to work on policy, and I'd like to improve the system. Right now, SFMTA is hiring people who don't know the city, or the customer base, and I think it's key to know how local passengers behave, who the residents of San Francisco are."

During the summer of 2019, Alex was on a Critical Incidents Leave without pay for ninety days while he waited to hear from management about his claim. He was dismayed about the wait and was eager to return to work. "Fortunately, I had savings, but for another driver a wait like that could be an economic catastrophe. Why should it take them ninety days to review my case? This is why drivers don't report."

There are other changes he would like to see.

"First, the scheduling system. For example, why not give operators the option of working a four-day week with a ten-hour shift straight through? If you can't get rid of the splits, which are an unpaid break between runs, at least the four-day option would reduce the number of twelve-hour days, which some operators already do, sometimes seven days a week. A four-day work week would mean operators who commute—from Antioch, from Sacramento—they would save on transportation, lunch, gas, bridge toll, and get a three-day break.

PHOTO CREDIT:
MUNI IS MY RIDE

“Second, passengers need education. It’s getting so busy, so much harder to navigate the city, so passenger behavior has to change. Muni is always pushing ‘safety,’ but it’s only a word. They don’t provide any rules for passengers that will help create a safe environment. People board and disembark while they’re looking at their phones. I do my best to be friendly. ‘Hey, do me a favor, I know you’re in a rush, you have somewhere to go, but those are stairs, [and your accident means me stopping the train and blocking traffic]. But those aren’t the hard parts.’” Alex pauses to demonstrate how he delivers his punch line: “‘The hard part for me is the reports. I don’t like filling out accident reports.’”

“I am very understanding because all the drivers, we’re not consistent. Rules change and some operators don’t enforce the rules. ‘Hey, I have to let you know *the new rule*. I can’t move the train until you fold your scooter up.’ The kids, the teenagers, the adults, they listen to me. But the baby strollers, I don’t know. They’ve gotten bigger and bigger and bigger. And people with these strollers get on the back doors, and no one can get past them during rush hour.

“Also, passengers over-depend on the driver. ‘The operator didn’t take action.’ That’s a chief complaint. Passengers can take action, switch their seat, speak up. But the majority do nothing. If I take action, I get disciplined. *Did you do right? Did you do wrong? Next time, you have got to do this.* An accident happens and people out on the street will jump on the bus to be a plaintiff in the lawsuit since there’s a ‘the city will pay’ mindset. ‘Well, that’s very nice but the video shows you weren’t on board when the accident happened.’

“Ironically, the videos don’t help the drivers, though they should. When a supervisor asked me about a complaint, I said, ‘I would like you to look at the video and only call me in if the video shows the passenger’s complaint is true.’ Turns out the video showed the passenger verbally attacking me for nothing, and nice thing, the supervisor apologized to me. They should look at the videos before they call us in.

“Third, is the re-routes for events, like Lunar New Year and Pride, permit events. I don’t know why the re-routes change every year. And these decisions are made without the input of the operators. Operators are in the best position to say what works and what doesn’t, what’s happening on the ground, but no one talks to us.”

Alex is dynamically interactive, knows his regulars, and strives to make the ride pleasant. “When I wake up, I can be in any kind of mood, sad, happy, worried, but I’ve figured it out that no one cares about my feelings. I don’t bring my personal feelings onto the train. My philosophy is: I get kids to school, passengers to work, tourists there with a smile, if I can. It’s the city, so getting you there is never going to be promptly. People ask me how I deal with the stress, and I say, ‘My oily showers.’” Alex grins. “It all just slips right off because I’ve had my oily shower. I could say there’s a sharp line between my job and my personal life.”

“I will wait for my regulars, but I tell commuters to find another way during rush hours when everyone is cutting in front of the F line, even our own brother buses. We’re slow, and we’re on a track.

“I tell people with strollers, ‘I’m going to let you on the front, but if an elderly person steps on, you have to move back. Our priority is the elderly, and the disabled. You have to be kind and helpful.’ The tourists, they follow rules. The locals, I can’t say they do. I tell my passengers to treat my train like an airplane. ‘Please wait until I come to a complete stop before you unlock your stroller wheels.’

“I’m always problem solving. Like these two ladies, with their two strollers, they were my regulars but started coming on during rush hour. So, one day, I stepped off the car and pointed out how my follower, the streetcar behind me, was empty. ‘I love to see you, but in two minutes you and your babies are going to have a whole train to yourselves.’ And they listened to me. I never tell passengers, *Another car is coming*, because that could be thirty minutes, but if I can visually show them the next streetcar is on its way, it’s going to help everyone out.”

Original text excerpt and image of Alex Rodriguez from Muni Is My Ride: Portraits of Muni in Words and Images, published by Ithuriel’s Spear Press, 2023, copyright © 2023 by Keith S. Ferris and Lia Smith. All rights reserved.



PHOTO CREDIT:
JACK SLOOP



TRANSIT FIRST POLICY REVIEW: WHERE ARE WE NOW?

- JOSE ALVAREZ

On the corner of Stockton and Washington streets stands the entrance to Chinatown-Rose Pak Station, in the heart of the “most densely populated urban area west of Manhattan” per the San Francisco Planning Department. I pause at the crosswalk as a 30 Stockton bus whirs uphill and lurches to a stop outside the station. As the pedestrian signal blinks to the “walk” sign, dozens of people begin to cross the street, passing on either side of me. Twelve stories beneath this busy intersection sits the deepest Muni Metro station in San Francisco.

This is one of three stations within the Central Subway tunnel, a project which opened for full service in 2023 and now allows commuters in San Francisco’s densest neighborhood to reach the 4th Street Caltrain station in only 10 minutes. Voters first approved the project in 2003, and the subway section ultimately cost nearly \$2 billion and took a decade to complete after construction started. For all the costs and complexity surrounding this megaproject, however, one thing is clear: public transit-based undertakings of this magnitude are incredibly rare to see in the United States today. That this subway even exists speaks volumes about the city’s ambitions and priorities.

To understand how San Francisco came to have the will to build at this scale, we have to go back to the 1970s.

San Francisco’s Transit-First policy was initially adopted on March 19, 1973, marking a major turning point following decades of increasingly car-oriented development. Only a few decades before Transit-First, San Francisco adopted a plan that would have resulted in a number of freeways slicing through the city, along with a slew of multi-block parking garages to accommodate increased demand for parking spots. The plan was ultimately unpopular enough that the Board of Supervisors voted to cancel the plans to construct the majority of the freeways after a public outcry (part of what is now known as the San Francisco Freeway Revolt). While many other American cities were fully embracing an automobile-centric approach to urban planning, San Francisco was moving in the opposite direction. San Francisco’s Transit-First policy would, in its own words, “[establish] public transit priority over the private vehicle [to] discourage automobile use and thus encourage greater use of transit.” The actual written policy is relatively short (the amended version from 2007 is only around 400 words in length), and reads much more like a written manifesto than a typical piece of municipal code.

PHOTO CREDIT:
SFMTA PHOTO ARCHIVE

While Transit-First was formally adopted in the 1970s, the policy continued to expand in the decades that followed. In 1999, voters passed Proposition E, which strengthened Transit-First, added protections for pedestrians and cyclists, and cemented the policy into the City Charter. The policy was amended again through the passage of Proposition A in 2007. The initial policy painted, in broad strokes, a picture of a city where public transit took priority over the personal automobile. But the reality of San Francisco is that it is a city operating with a finite amount of street space, and every decision regarding a bus lane, sidewalk, parking spot, or bike lane represents what the city considers to be a priority.

**MORE THAN 50 YEARS LATER, WE’RE
ABLE TO VIEW TRANSIT-FIRST AS AN
EVOLVING FRAMEWORK FOR THE
FUNDAMENTAL QUESTION OF WHO SAN
FRANCISCO’S STREETS ARE FOR.**

The transportation landscape of San Francisco, of course, has changed substantially and only become more complicated since the 1970s.

Uber and Lyft, both of which have become integral to the lives of many in the Bay Area, were founded in San Francisco in 2009 and 2012, respectively. Autonomous vehicles, such as those from Waymo, are now ubiquitous on the streets of San Francisco, but only began operating full commercial passenger services in 2023. San Franciscans today have perhaps more ways of getting around than they have ever had before.

This proliferation of services has already begun to test what Transit-First really means today.

Large portions of Market Street were previously declared “car-free”, a plan which was partially reversed in 2025 to allow for certain rideshare vehicles to drive down the corridor. Given Market Street’s stature as one of the most central thoroughfares in the city, this compromise shows that the question of who San Francisco’s streets are for remains far from settled.

Back in Rose Pak Station, I tap my phone on the card reader and walk over to the first of multiple escalators that zig-zag down to the platform. On a Saturday afternoon, the T is about a quarter full. I slip into the car and find a seat moments before the doors begin to close. Having just come from a quick lunch in Chinatown, I’m now on my way to meet up with friends in China Basin Park to watch a World Cup match in about an hour.

There’s an odd comfort in being on a train 100 feet underground, far removed from all the buses, cars, and people above. I look out the window as the train begins to accelerate, and my view of the station quickly becomes a blur of darkness through the glass. I check my phone to see how long it will take me to arrive.

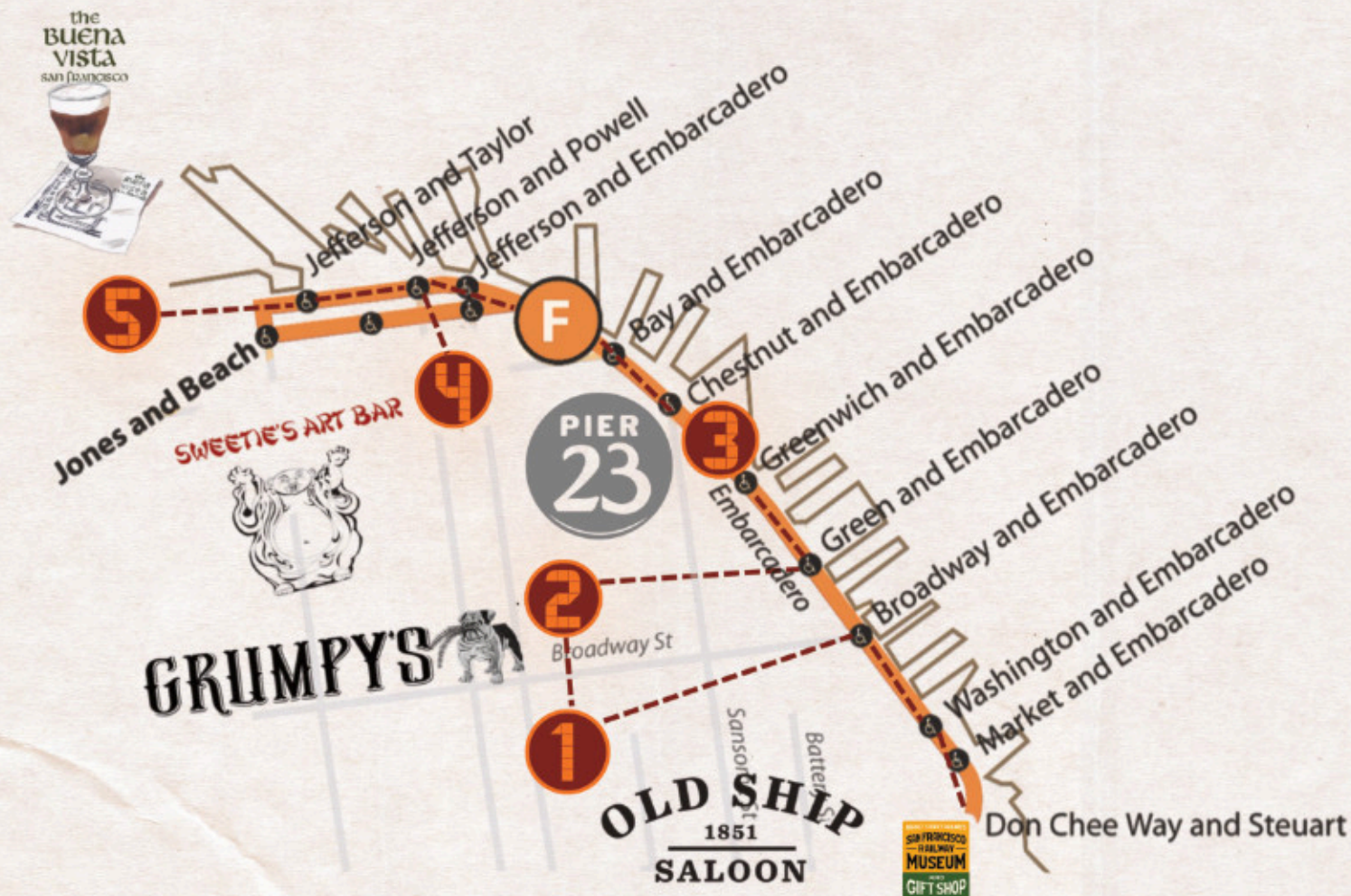
Fifteen minutes. Not bad.



PHOTO CREDIT:
SFMTA PHOTO ARCHIVE



F LINE BAR CRAWL



- ① OLD SHIP SALOON
- ② GRUMPY'S
- ③ PIER 23
- ④ SWEETIE'S ART BAR
- ⑤ THE BUENA VISTA

KICKOFF EVENT
SF RAILWAY MUSEUM
THURSDAY SEPT 10
AT 6PM
77 STEUART STREET

SHIPWRECKS, SAZERACS, AND STREETCARS

MARKET STREET RAILWAY'S F-LINE HISTORIC BAR CRAWL RETURNS, THIS TIME DOWN THE EMBARCADERO

- INDIGO ROSENBERG

Last year, Market Street Railway sent its first historic bar crawl rattling up Market Street. This year, the event will be returning to celebrate Bay Area Transit Month, and this time, we'll be sailing down the Embarcadero. Every stop along the way carries its own strange, well-aged story, and, fortunately, a drink worth ordering to go with it.

The night begins at the San Francisco Railway Museum, where we'll board the streetcar to our first bar: the **OLD SHIP SALOON**. Few bars in the city can claim a founding story like this. Originally making its debut as the Old Ship Alehouse in 1851, amid the delirium of the Gold Rush, the bar first operated from the side of a ship (The Arkansas) that had run aground. As the city expanded and filled in its shoreline, the wrecked ship was buried beneath what is now downtown San Francisco, and the current building was built directly on top of it.

Our next stop, **GRUMPY'S**, is just a short walk from the Old Ship Saloon. Tucked inside a historic brick building dating back to 1936, it's located in what was once the heart of San Francisco's advertising and media industry, surrounded by the city's leading ad agencies and television and radio stations. Back then, Grumpy's was the watering hole for the workers who needed to unwind after clocking out. Although the beloved pub (briefly) closed in December 2020, thankfully it has since reopened under new ownership with a refreshed look and an updated menu that still nods to its after-work-drink roots.

Back on the streetcar, we'll head to **PIER 23**, a bar that has quietly reinvented itself without ever losing its footing. It got its start as one of the many waterfront coffee houses that longshoremen frequented between shifts, then evolved into a neighborhood bar filled with live music, earning its reputation as one of the city's favorite waterfront haunts. By the time the 1950s rolled around, it was widely known for its jazz and live performances, a tradition still thriving today. While the drink and food offerings have changed over the years, the warmth hasn't. Today, it stands firm as one of the best places to enjoy live music with a view of the Bay to match.

Next up: **SWEETIE'S ART BAR**, which sits beside the former site of one of the city's most bizarre bars, the Cobweb Palace, opened by Abe Warner in 1856. Back then, the Cobweb Palace was a saloon packed with curiosities from around the world, complemented by monkeys and parrots wandering freely around the bar. But its real claim to fame was found overhead. Warner refused to clean the ceiling, letting spiders spin undisturbed for years, until the cobwebs themselves became the bar's signature and namesake. It's all a strange bit of Gold Rush-era San Francisco lore that Sweetie's proudly carries forward today.

The crawl ends where the cable car turnaround meets the waterfront, at The Buena Vista, a bar whose legacy rests on a single, perfect caffeinated beverage. Opened in 1916 as a neighborhood saloon, they found fame through their Irish coffee, a drink their bartenders arguably perfected. In 1952, travel writer Stanton Delaplane returned from a trip to Ireland determined to recreate the coffee he had there, and teamed up with **BUENA VISTA** owner Jack Koeppler to crack the code. After countless rounds of trial and error, lots of Tullamore and even more heavy cream, they discovered that the cream must be aged just right to float. More than 70 years later, the Buena Vista's Irish coffee is still the gold standard by which the rest of the city's are measured.

Six bars that will take you on a journey through six eras of San Francisco — all connected by the same rails that carried this city into being. Come curious, and come thirsty. After all, you're not driving.

TAP ON, CROSS OFF: MUNI BINGO

- CURATED BY KAREN KYI

Want to spice up your daily commute? Playing tour guide for out-of-town friends? Or just craving a little whimsy? Take on our Muni bingo challenge during Transit Month to support public transit and explore the city. Squint out the window, keep your eyes peeled, and start crossing off the typical Muni moments and dare to take on the wildcard squares for more adventure.

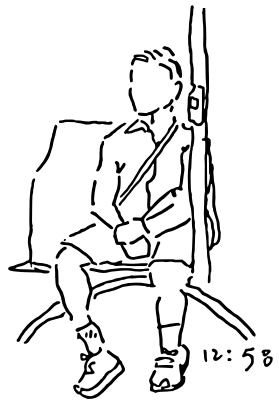


PHOTO CREDIT:
JESSICA JOY BALAORO
& JACK SLOOP

TAKE A SELFIE WITH YOUR FAVORITE OPERATOR OR STATION AGENT	RIDE A LINE FROM START TO FINISH	VISIT THE SAN FRANCISCO RAILWAY MUSEUM	HOP ON THE M TO GRAB A BITE AT THE M STOP HALAL DELI
HOP ON A CABLE CAR	M U L T I P L E PEOPLE HIT THE STOP REQUEST BUTTON FOR THE SAME STOP	FREEHAND DRAW THE ICONIC MUNI LOGO WHILE WAITING FOR / RIDING THE BUS	EXPERIENCE A SEAMLESS TRANSFER!
CHECK OUT THE CABLE CAR MUSEUM	SEE A RIDER ROCKING THE NEW SFPL SUMMER STRIDE TOTE DURING YOUR COMMUTE	GIVE UP YOUR SEAT THAT IS NOT IN THE FRONT / DESIGNATED SECTION	YOUR DRIVER WAVES OR HONKS AT A FELLOW DRIVER PASSING BY
RIDE A V I N T A G E STREETCAR	A CAR IS DOUBLE PARKED IN THE BUS LANE	SPOT A FURRY FRIEND (OR ANY ANIMAL) ON YOUR RIDE	SEE AT LEAST 3 RIDERS ON YOUR BUS OR TRAIN REPPING A BAY AREA SPORTS TEAM

CREATURES OF MUNI

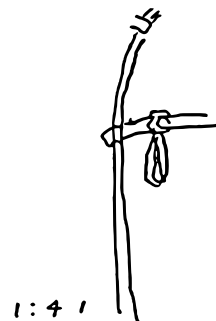
1pm on a saturday



"THIS STOP
IS:"



"PLS HOLD
ON"



observed by
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MISSION OF
CONVERTING
EVERY SAN
FRANCISCO
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